



Neither Religion nor Politics

A rule with a reason

LORE

Not squeamishness, and not neutrality for its own sake. A deliberate design decision taken in a country that had just spent a century killing itself over both.

ON THE TABLE

Anderson's Constitutions, 1723 — the text of Charge I

HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
1:15	What the rule actually says
2:45	Now put a date on it
5:00	The genuinely radical part
6:45	What it cost, and what it bought
8:15	Saying it better
9:15	Closing

THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 Anderson's Constitutions, 1723, Charge VI.2 — resolved against all politics.
- 2 Written by men whose fathers had seen civil war, a king beheaded, penal laws and the '15.
- 3 It is not an absence of conviction. It is an agreement about what we will not use against each other.

IF YOU ARE ASKED

Where is this written?

Anderson's Constitutions, 1723, Charge I (God and Religion) and Charge VI.2 (Behaviour in the Lodge).

Does it mean masons have no beliefs?

The opposite. A belief in a Supreme Being is required. What is excluded is argument about whose.

Why does it make people suspicious?

Because a body that will not state a position invites others to invent one for it. That has been the cost from the beginning.

Has it ever been relaxed?

No. It remains in the Book of Constitutions and in every lodge's practice.

SOURCES

- James Anderson, The Constitutions of the Free-Masons, London, 1723 — full text widely available in facsimile
- UGLE Book of Constitutions, current edition
- Margaret Jacob, Living the Enlightenment — on masonry and eighteenth-century sociability
- John Hamill, The Craft: A History of English Freemasonry

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